

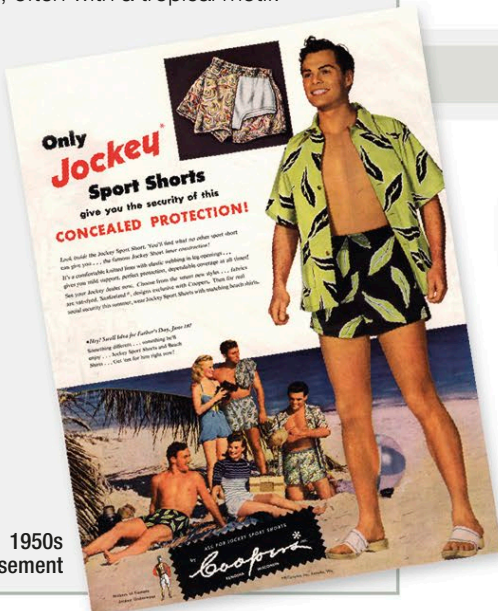
1950–1961

RESORT WEAR

The prosperity of the 1950s brought the concept of leisure to the mainstream. It was no longer just the wealthy who had time and money to take holidays; and as air travel became less exclusive, more people ventured abroad. The upper class had mastered the art of dressing for travel and leisure long ago, and now the middle class embraced the idea. Responding to a burgeoning market, the fashion industry produced a new category of clothing known as resort wear, comprising diverse ranges of holiday clothes and accessories. Although “resort” implied a casual look, people dressed up, if in more colourful and revealing clothes than for everyday life. That meant playsuits, beach dresses, bathing suits, and coordinating cover-ups for women, and matching swim shorts and short-sleeved shirts for men. Vivid fabrics, including Hawaiian florals, Indonesian batik, and animal prints, were widely used. Tropical-themed accessories were an important part of the look.

MEN ON HOLIDAY

It was not only women who liked colourful leisure clothes. When men took time off, they usually opted to break out of the conservative attire of the 1950s workplace and embrace flamboyance. Men's short-sleeved shirts and coordinating swim shorts were sold in an array of patterns and colours, often with a tropical motif.



1950s advertisement



Matching beach coat Abstract fabrics were big news in fashion from the late 1940s through to the 1950s, and this pairing uses them to great effect. An elasticated cotton swimsuit is partnered with a terry-cloth robe in a complementary print.

High-waisted bikini Brigitte Bardot helped to make the bikini popular when she posed in one at the Cannes Film Festival in 1953. This design, in a charming foliage and floral print, is typical of the era, with plenty of support built into the bikini top.

Separates Summer wear comprising matching separates – such as skirts, suntops, blouses, and shorts – was fashionable on the beach. The various elements of this 1956 striped outfit could be bought one at a time.